



Cover story | CHALLENGES OF CHANGE

other, if we were to take actions where we are increasing the gulf between them—that is certainly not the direction of peace. We have to reduce the trust deficit through genuine confidence building measures. We are victims together of terrorism and extremism and we have to go together to look for solutions to terrorism and extremism.

Having done this—improving the environment—we must then take on resolution of disputes with true sincerity, flexibility and boldness. Boldness is very important; unless boldness is there, sincerity and flexibility and understanding is meaningless.

We have to head for a solution on Kashmir. I had given a formula which could form the basis for moving forward and taking it towards a solution. The formula included identifying the zones of Kashmir, going for graduated demilitarisation, especially from the cities, so that the people of Kashmir can heave a sigh of relief, giving maximum self-governance to the people of Kashmir and having some kind of an over-watch on self-governance. We even thought of making the LOC irrelevant. I think this is another Berlin Wall which needs to be torn down and not kept so water-tight that people cannot even meet each other, their families and relatives.

Siachen is the other dispute. I think it is the easiest to solve because both the countries are suffering. We must disengage and demilitarise. Sir Creek is the third dispute. We must go for a compromise solution that is very much possible. Even if all the mineral wealth, all the oil and gas of the world are within this area that we are fighting over, we must find a common solution. Last is the water dispute. I think futuristically this portends danger. We must not open new fronts and we must stick to the Indus Water Treaty.

I feel we must show resolve to solve them and, in the words of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, "we must pick the threads again" from where we left and start moving forward. We must start meeting for dispute resolution at the committee level and at the summit level. We must also initiate confidence building measures without any loss of time, we must stop unconsidered accusations against each other and also we must stop meddling in each other's domestic affairs. And then we should also restart back-channel diplomacy.

There is a dire need of an attitudinal change at both ends—more in India, less in Pakistan. You have to accept reality and the sovereign



"I WOULD LIKE TO PLAY THE ROLE OF A THIRD UMPIRE BETWEEN INDIA AND PAKISTAN IN THE PEACE PROCESS."

PERVEZ MUSHARRAF

equality of Pakistan, because I know that in some quarters in India this is not acceptable. We have to change and improve public perceptions of each other. We see Pakistan-bashing, Pakistan army-bashing, ISI-bashing and maligning of our society in your media. I remember when Advani *sahab* came to Pakistan and I think he praised or said some good words about Qaid-e-Azam, Mohammed Ali Jinnah. I remember the uproar in India and I think he was forced to resign.

India has to show magnanimity and humility; one cannot be a large country with a small heart. Kashmir remains the key dispute and the sore point. It has had a freedom struggle since 1947 and from 1989 onwards, this non-violent movement turned into a militant struggle. This has a direct impact on Pakistan's society. There is an emotional involvement of the people of Pakistan with the people of Kashmir. Therefore, this has given rise to dozens of freelance mujahideen groups and it is encouraging militancy in Pakistan which certainly needs to be controlled. But the task of controlling these dozens

Q. What is the future of Indo-Pak relations? What do you think will change in the future which makes you an optimist?

A. I believe an attitudinal change is required. I said the core issue is the issue of people of Pakistan and India developing more affinity towards each other. Then we need to move forward towards resolution of disputes and have to address the issues of terrorism and extremism together. We should also stop meddling in each other's internal affairs.

Q. The 26/11 terror attack was like an act of invasion and the reaction we got from Pakistan was disappointing. Do you think Pakistani state agencies were involved?

A. I don't want to comment on what the Pakistan Government did or did not. It was most unfortunate. It was a terrorist attack and terrorists have no nationality. Right from